

Well, our definition of web services in this book is anything that you can do online for real-world customers. This could be a simple email solution, a basic web site, or even a portal with a payment gateway so that your customer can sell goods online and accept orders online.

Basically, we've seen a marked rise in the need for small businesses to get online, and it doesn't matter what that business is, because these days it's honestly more of a necessity than a gimmick. Although the idea of making money from businesses by helping them tap into the world of the internet can scarcely be considered novel, it's only in the past few years that the demand has risen to a point where it is a serious business opportunity.

Let's first look at why this has happened...

